

+ Prime focus

+ We're doing more



After more than 23 years supporting Queensland's primary producers, QRAA became the Queensland Rural and Industry Development Authority (QRIDA) on 1 July 2017.

We are staying true to our history and values as a trusted financial partner, while embracing the larger role we have to play that will help us do more for Queenslanders like you.

QRIDA Chief Executive Officer, Cameron MacMillan, says that our name change allows us to build on our strong history and expand our service offerings to clients.

"The expansion of our role means we're making better use of our longstanding knowledge and passion, and doing more for the benefit of Queensland's rural and regional industries," Mr MacMillan said.

"In 2016-17 we delivered almost \$250 million in loans and grants covering on-farm productivity, industry adjustment, farm succession, drought and natural disaster on behalf of the Queensland and Australian governments.

"The expansion of our role means we're making better use of our longstanding knowledge and passion, and doing more for the benefit of Queensland's rural and regional industries."

"Yet we are more than just a loan and grant administrator – over the past 23 years QRAA, now QRIDA, has become a specialist in rural finance and supporting regional Queensland," he said.

Some of the key things that 1 July brought to QRIDA, and to Queensland, include:

Farm Business Debt Mediation: Replacing a previous voluntary scheme, the new Farm Business Debt Mediation program is now mandatory in Queensland. More information is available in the article over the page.

Being a voice for rural Queensland: As QRIDA, we now have a policy and advice role. Using our understanding of lending, grants administration and rural and regional Queensland, we are undertaking research and advising government.

Increases and updates on existing programs: Although separate to our transition to QRIDA, a number of exciting things also happened to our existing offerings on 1 July:

- After unprecedented demand in 2016-17 which saw funds fully committed, our First Start and Sustainability Loans are now open for application again, with \$120 million available in 2017-18. Interest rates for these loans have also dropped.
- The Australian Government funded Drought Assistance Concessional Loans have been extended into 2017-18 and new Business Improvement Concessional Loans have been introduced to help producers recover from financial hardship.

For more information on our schemes, services, and how we are doing more for Queensland, contact us on **Freecall 1800 623 946** or visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au.

Inside

From the CEO's desk	2
Farm Debt Mediation	2
QRIDA in action	3
Regional update	4

To receive *Prime Focus* by email or unsubscribe, contact us on **Freecall 1800 623 946** or email contact_us@qrida.qld.gov.au

Freecall 1800 623 946
www.qrida.qld.gov.au

/QRIDAMedia

/QRIDAMedia

/company/QRIDA



From the CEO's desk

It's hard to believe we're already over halfway through a busy year, with no sign of slowing down.

Since the start of 2017, we've changed our name, introduced Farm Business Debt Mediation, launched new programs, fully committed all funding for First Start and Sustainability Loans (and reopened them on 1 July), established a ninth office in Cloncurry, supported those impacted by Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie and more.

For me, one of the most exciting things to happen this year is the introduction of Farm Management Grants. Providing up to \$2,500 per year towards the costs of professional advice on family farm transfers, this program was introduced to encourage more of Queensland's farming families to get serious about succession, a process crucial to the future of our rural sector. And with over 250 applications submitted since the scheme opened in March, it seems to be well on track to achieving this objective.

I'm a strong believer in every producer having a "village" around them – a team



QRIDA CEO, Cameron MacMillan (left), with the QRIDA Board and Regional Area Manager for the North West and Gulf, Janessa Bidgood, visiting QRIDA clients Robert & Jacqueline Curley

of trusted advisors and professionals who will help you do what's best for your business and family. I'm thrilled that our organisation is able to deliver a program that makes it more affordable for farming families to engage these professionals, making it easier to bring the family together for serious, productive discussions about the future.

Don't forget, multiple family members are able to obtain advice and receive the grants individually, and more than one payment can be received up to the total of \$2,500.

The grants are ideal for families considering our First Start Loans, which

provide the next generation with up to \$2 million to establish their first primary production enterprise. Many of our clients have used a First Start Loan to take over the family business, and with these loans now available with interest rates as low as 3.02 per cent there's never been a better time to look into your options.

I encourage our clients to get in touch with their local Regional Area Manager to discuss what's possible with both Farm Management Grants and First Start Loans, and look forward to continuing to support the next generation's transition onto the land.

Cameron MacMillan

Farm Business Debt Mediation Scheme now mandatory



The *Farm Business Debt Mediation Act 2017* (Qld) was passed in Queensland Parliament in March, paving the way for the 1 July launch of our administration of the Farm Business Debt Mediation Scheme in Queensland.

The scheme prevents lenders from foreclosing on farming properties without first offering formal mediation and replaces a previous voluntary scheme which was part of the Farm Finance Strategy.

The Act applies to disputes relating to business debts secured by a mortgage and includes debts on farming land, water assets, vehicles, machinery and other assets used in the farming business.

Chief Executive Officer, Cameron MacMillan, says QRIDA is committed to ensuring farm businesses have access to a fair process which benefits mortgagees and farmers.

"The scheme is confidential and aims to provide an equitable and efficient resolution without resorting to expensive, drawn-out legal processes – protecting our farmers at a time when they're at their most vulnerable."

"Our role will see that the interests of both farmers and mortgagees are considered by ensuring mediation is undertaken before any mortgagee enforcement action can be made," he said.

"Our role will see that the interests of both farmers and mortgagees are considered..."

"In developing the scheme we reviewed similar legislation in New South Wales and Victoria, and also consulted extensively with key stakeholders such as the Queensland Farmers' Federation, AgForce, the Queensland Law Society and the Australian Bankers' Association."

"This enabled us to leverage best practices and design a framework that provides an equitable and efficient way for farmers and mortgagees to resolve matters relating to farm business debts."

Further information is available at www.qrida.qld.gov.au/fbdtm or by contacting QRIDA on Freecall 1800 623 946.

+ QRIDA in action



QRIDA clients, Wendy and Jim Brodie on their property 'Redland Park', east of McKinlay, North West Queensland

Sustainability Loan strengthens graziers' operations

Our Board of Directors regularly travel across Queensland, hearing what matters to locals and seeing first-hand how our programs are helping clients rise to the challenges of life on the land and achieve their goals.

Recently they paid a visit to Wendy and Jim Brodie, whose cattle operation is a prime example of how smart business management and support from us can help producers thrive – even in tough conditions like drought.

With an extensive background in the beef industry, the Brodies have lived at 'Redland Park,' east of McKinlay, since leaving family property at Roma over 30 years ago. Their breeder operation mates Santa Gertrudis X Charolais cows to Angus and Santa Gertrudis bulls, with

steers turned off into the heavy feeder market or grown into bullocks depending on the season.

"We control mate our cows and yearling heifers from February to June. Females are then pregnancy tested into calving groups to calf from November to January and February to March," Jim explains.

"These different calving groups help with managing nutritional requirements – like cows calving early before wet season requiring supplementation - and ease of mustering and other husbandry activities."

A key part of Jim and Wendy's operation is strictly matching stocking rates to available grass – "we perform annual grass budgets to calculate the amount of grass available and adjust our stocking rates accordingly," says Jim

When it recently came time to further boost their carrying capacity Wendy and Jim partnered with us, purchasing a nearby property with the help of a Sustainability Loan. Supporting the long term productivity and profitability of Queensland farm businesses, these loans provide up to \$1.3 million for expansion, upgrades and other on-farm

Interest rates

(First Start and Sustainability Loans)

1 year fixed	3.02%
3 year fixed	3.15%
5 year fixed	3.44%

Current for First Start and Sustainability Loans drawn down from 1 July 2017 and may be subject to change.

improvements. Repayment terms of up to 20 years are available, with interest rates currently as low as 3.02 per cent.

Jim said the application process was clear and straightforward – "with just a phone call or email, we were given all the support we needed" – and the couple would recommend the program to other producers.

With our Cloncurry office now open, North West graziers will have even more support when enquiring about or applying for loans.

Visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au to find out more about the programs, or to locate your nearest Regional Area Manager.

QRIDA delivers Sustainability Loans on behalf of the Queensland Government.



+ Regional update



Sam Spina
Far North

P: 07 4064 2824
M: 0429 497 757
sam.spina@qrida.qld.gov.au

Sustainability Loans aid biosecurity

Queensland producers are well aware of the number of biosecurity threats this state faces.

Sustainability Loans are ideal for assisting producers implement biosecurity procedures and infrastructure.

Whether expenditure is required to duplicate farm vehicles on multiple sites, configure packing sheds, fence properties or manage vehicle access, Sustainability Loans can be tailored to match your cash flows and business requirements.

Please contact me to find out how our loans can assist you.



Peter Crowley
North

P: 07 4967 0728
M: 0427 770 147
peter.crowley@qrida.qld.gov.au

TC Debbie response continues

QRIDA has made a significant commitment to the recovery of the region since the cyclone, working with those affected to get them operational.

We will continue to be on the ground to assist with grant and loan applications. Grants of up to \$25,000 are available to repair, restore and replace items that cannot be repaired. Applications for these close on October 13; all work needs to be completed and paid for by this date. Loans with an interest rate of 1.16% are also available to assist with expenses in excess of the grant and to fund day to day expenses as businesses recover.



Kate Dunk
Darling Downs and Lockyer

P: 07 4634 8987
M: 0427 690 448
kate.dunk@qrida.qld.gov.au

Grants provide future for farming families

It has been terrific to see the uptake of Farm Management Grants by farming families with the support of professionals in my region.

Succession planning can take some time and requires a lot of communication. As such, the grants are available for another two years, are open to all family members involved with farm succession and allow individuals to claim up to \$2,500 per annum.

Hopefully once succession plans are settled, we can assist clients turn their plans into reality with the use of our low interest First Start Loans.



Mark Barrett
Wide Bay and Fraser Coast

P: 07 4154 2874
M: 0417 775 547
mark.barrett@qrida.qld.gov.au

Improve energy efficiency

Energy efficiency is at the forefront of many growers' minds in my area. QRIDA has been very proactive in supporting Canegrowers and QFF to improve knowledge of alternate energy sources and encourage on-farm investment to manage production costs.

In particular, our Sustainability Loans can assist with alternate energy generation or the installation of energy efficient plant and equipment. We have assisted a range of industries from dairy to sugarcane through to fruit and vegetables with these measures.

Please contact me to discuss your options.



Bill Fletcher
Burnett and Sunshine Coast

P: 07 4182 1816
M: 0417 778 317
bill.fletcher@qrida.qld.gov.au

Recent rainfall benefits Burnett

This region has benefited from the rainfall produced by Tropical Cyclone Debbie and as such the outlook for coming months is quite good.

Avocado and macadamia growers have experienced excellent prices and have shown significant interest in utilising Sustainability Loans to assist with increasing their orchards and upgrading their sorting and packing sheds.

I am available to meet on farm and discuss your productivity initiatives - call me to make an appointment.



Bradley Whittington
Central Highlands and West

P: 07 4987 5807
M: 0417 775 345
bradley.whittington@qrida.qld.gov.au

Drought conditions continue in the west

Graziers in the western areas are destocking as conditions failed to improve in late summer and a cool dry winter ensued. In addition, farms in the Emerald area have been impacted by limited soil moisture.

It is timely to remember that Drought Assistance Concessional Loans are available for producers when they have been financially impacted by drought for a two year period, including the upcoming season.

Now is the time to take advantage of these loans to have your business better placed when the seasons improve.



Tony Koch
Maranoa and South West

P: 07 4622 8527
M: 0427 029 141
tony.koch@qrida.qld.gov.au

New Business Improvement Loan available

It has been a privilege to support so many producers in the area over the past year with the full range of QRIDA's available schemes.

I look forward to assisting producers who will be eligible for the new Business Improvement Concessional Loan that was launched on 7 July.

A large part of my area was impacted by the most recent drought quite early. This new loan assists producers coming off three years of Farm Household Allowance through refinancing 50% of commercial debt up to \$1 million.

Please contact me to find out more.



John Lacey
Capricornia

P: 07 4936 1872
M: 0417 775 245
john.lacey@qrida.qld.gov.au

Drought loans assist with restructuring

In spite of some impact from Tropical Cyclone Debbie, many areas in my region are still experiencing very dry conditions.

For instance, a large part of the Banana region is impacted by a 1 in 20 year rainfall deficiency.

In light of these conditions, I remind producers about Drought Assistance Concessional Loans that can assist with debt restructure to ease cashflow concerns or borrowing additional funds to assist with day to day expenses. The loan's interest rate of 3.09% and option of five years interest only are suited to assisting during tight times.



Janessa Bidgood
North West & Gulf

P: 1800 623 946
M: 0427 007 240
janessa.bidgood@qrida.qld.gov.au

Succession a hot topic in North West

Enquiry continues to lift in my area as the opportunity that our loans present are fully realised by producers in the region.

Good cattle prices have provided a sound base for succession discussions to take place and with interest rates as low as 3.02%, grazing families are seeing the sense in encouraging the next generation into their grazing enterprise.

I am continuing to travel and cover my whole territory so please call and make an appointment to discuss the assistance we may have available for you.

Disclaimer: The information provided by QRIDA is general information only and has been prepared without taking into account your individual objectives, financial situation and needs. Before applying for financial assistance or making any decision, you should obtain and read a copy of the relevant program guidelines and seek advice from your legal, business and financial advisers to determine your eligibility for, and the terms of the relevant financial assistance. You should note that past grants of financial assistance are not a reliable indicator of eligibility for future grants of financial assistance. The information provided by QRIDA has been taken from sources believed to be reliable however QRIDA does not represent that the information is accurate or complete and it should not be relied upon as such. QRIDA does not assume any common law duty of care towards you in providing the information and QRIDA will not be liable for any loss or damage however caused (including by the negligence of QRIDA), suffered or incurred by you in connection with information provided by QRIDA.